Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

1.1 Metadata

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 27-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at:
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1.2 Definitions

- **file** - data on storage device, e.g., hard disk or ssd
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.3 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.4 Launching

```
helix
helix <file>
helix <file1> <file2> ... <filen>
helix <directory>
helix --help
hx in some distributions or by alias
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Editing Paradigm

Selection first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
        v3wd – enter select mode, select 3 words, delete
```

2.2 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

```
      .  – any character
      *  – zero or more
      +  – one or more
      ?  – zero or one / lazy match
      ^  – start of line / negation in class
      $  – end of line
   (  )  – capture group
   [  ]  – character class
   {  }  – repetition count
      |  – alternation
      \  – escape character itself
```

2.3 Essentials

2.3.1 Undo / Repeat / Normal Mode

`u / U`	– undo / redo change in linear history
`Alt-u / Alt-U`	– move backward / forward in tree history
`:ear / :lat`	– move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
`<nn><cmd>`	– repeat <cmd> <nn> times
`Esc`	– return to normal mode

2.3.2 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

`:wq`	– write current buffer and quit
`:wq <file>`	– write current buffer to <file> and quit
`:wqa`	– write all buffer(s) and quit
`:q`	– quit current buffer, exits if last

2.3.3 Files

`:o <file>`	– open <file> in new buffer
`:w <file>`	– write current buffer to <file>
`:hs <file>`	– open/create <file> in new horizontal split
`:vs <file>`	– open/create <file> in new vertical split
`␣wf`	– open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
`␣wF`	– open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
`gf`	– open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
`␣f`	– open file picker at LSP workspace root
`␣F`	– open file picker at current working directory
`␣g`	– open changed file picker

2.3.3.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

`<enter>`	– open selected in current view
`Ctrl-s`	– open selected in new horizontal split
`Ctrl-v`	– open selected in new vertical split

2.3.4 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

`:n`	–	create new scratch buffer
`:bc`	–	close current buffer
`:bca`	–	close all buffers
`:bco`	–	close all but current buffer
`:bn`	–	next buffer
`␣b`	–	open buffer picker
`ga`	–	go to last accessed/alternate buffer
`gm`	–	go to last modified/alternate buffer
`gn`	–	go to next buffer
`gp`	–	go to previous buffer

2.3.5 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

`␣ws / ␣wv`	–	split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
`␣wns / ␣wnv`	–	split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
`␣wq`	–	close current split
`␣wo`	–	close all but current split
`␣ww`	–	next split
`␣wh/j/k/l`	–	move to buffer left / up / down / right
`␣wH/J/K/L`	–	swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
`␣wt`	–	transpose split

2.3.5.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
      Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

zz, zc – align to center
     zt – align to top
     zb – align to bottom
     zm – align to middle horizontally
     zj – scroll down
     zk – scroll up
```

2.3.6 Help

```
  :tutor – open tutorial
      ␣? – open command palette
```

2.4 Movement

2.4.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

h/j/k/l	–	left / up / down / right
gh, g|	–	beginning of line
<nn>g|	–	column <nn>
gl	–	end of line
gg	–	top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g	–	line <nn>
ge	–	bottom of file
gw	–	two-char labels on words, label to go to word
g.	–	to last modification in current file
gj	–	down textual line
gk	–	up textual line
gs	–	first non-white-space char
gt	–	top of screen
gc	–	middle of screen
gb	–	bottom of screen

2.4.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation

]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.4.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change

Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.4.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.5 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.5.1 Operations

```
     % – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i – shrink selection
     ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.5.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object
                  indicated by <ch> below:

          w / W – word / WORD
              p – paragraph
   (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
              m –  closest surround pair
              f – function
              t – type or class
              a – argument/parameter
              c – comment
              T – test
              g – change git hunk
```

2.5.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
    w / W – to start of next word / WORD
    e / E – to end of current word / WORD
    b / B – to start of current word / WORD
        x – current line, extend by line
        X – extend to line
   Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
       ]p – to next paragraph
       [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.5.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.5.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
      Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.6 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
        v – toggle select mode
      Esc – return to normal
        ) – cycle primary selection forward
        ( – cycle primary selection backward
    Alt-, – remove primary selection
```

2.7 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.7.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

`s<regex>`	– matches become selections
`S`	– split on match
`Alt-s`	– split on newlines
`C / Alt-C`	– add selection below / above

2.7.2 Operations

`&`	– align on primary cursor
`Alt-<minus>`	– merge selections
`Alt-<under>`	– merge consecutive selections
`,`	– remove all except primary selection
`Alt-,`	– remove primary selection
`( / )`	– rotate primary backwards / forwards
`Alt-( / Alt-)`	– rotate content backward / forward
`K`	– keep selections matching the regex
`Alt-K`	– remove selections matching the regex

2.8 Alter Buffer Content

2.8.1 Insert

`i`	–	before selection
`a`	–	after selection
`I`	–	at start of line
`A`	–	at end of line
`o`	–	add line and insert below cursor
`O`	–	add line and insert above cursor
`Esc`	–	end insert (return to normal)
`.`	–	repeat last insert

2.8.2 Add

`]␣`	–	newline below
`[␣`	–	newline above
`ms<ch>`	–	add delim <ch> around selection

2.8.3 Delete

`d`	–	selection -> yank buf, delete selection
`Alt-d`	–	delete, no save
`md<ch>`	–	delete delim <ch> around selection

2.8.4 Change

```
             c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
        Alt-c – change, no save
            = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.8.5 Indent Lines

```
          > – Indent line(s) containing selection
          < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.8.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
          ~ – change case
          ` – set lowercase
      Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.8.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
        ␣C – Toggle block comment
    ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.8.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.8.9 Miscellaneous

```
            J – join lines in a selection
      Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select
              the inserted space
    <under> – trim whitespace from selection
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <width>, default 80
     :sort – sort ranges in selection
   :format – format file using external
              formatter / language server
```

2.9 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
      y – selection -> yank buf
      p – paste yank buf after the cursor
      P – paste yank buf before the cursor
     ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
     ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
     ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
  r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
      R – replace selection with yank buf
      " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.10 Search

```
/<regex> – search forward for regex
?<regex> – search backward for regex
    n, N – next, previous match
       * – search for current selection, respect word
           boundaries
    Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.11 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
   "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
  "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
  "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
  "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.12 Macros

```
  "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
  "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.13 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
    ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.14 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
          mm – go to matching delim
     mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
     ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.15 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
       | – replace selection(s) with output
    Alt-| – ignore output
       ! –  insert output before each selection(s)
    Alt-! –  append output after each selection(s)
       $ –  keep selection(s) where command returned
            0
```

2.16 Approaching an IDE

`␣G` – debug - experimental
`␣k` – show documentation for item under cursor
`␣s` – open document symbol picker
`␣S` – open workspace symbol picker
`␣d` – open document diagnostics picker
`␣D` – open workspace diagnostics picker
`␣r` – rename symbol
`␣a` – apply code action
`␣h` – select symbol references for symbol under cursor

2.17 Editor Configuration

`:config-open` – open the config file
`:config-open-workspace` – open the workspace config file
`:config-reload` – reload the config file

2.18 Miscellaneous

`␣'` – open last picker
`␣/` – open global search in workspace folder picker

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

`Ctrl-s`	– commit undo checkpoint
`Ctrl-x`	– autocomplete
`Ctrl-r`	– insert a register content
`Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>`	– delete previous word
`Alt-d, Alt-<del>`	– delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	– delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	– delete to end of line
`Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>`	– delete previous char
`Ctrl-d, <del>`	– delete next char
`Ctrl-j, <enter>`	– insert new line
`<Up>, <Down>, <Left>, <Right>, <PageUp>, <PageDown>, <Home>, <End>`	– usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

`Esc, Ctrl-c`	– close prompt
`<enter>`	– open selected
`<tab>`	– select next completion item
`<backtab>`	– select previous completion item
`Alt-b`	– backward a word
`Ctrl-b`	– backward a char
`Alt-f`	– forward a word
`Ctrl-f`	– forward a char
`Ctrl-e`	– to prompt end
`Ctrl-a`	– to prompt start
`Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>`	– delete previous word
`Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>`	– delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	– delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	– delete to end of line
`<bksp>, Ctrl-h`	– delete previous char
`<del>, Ctrl-d`	– delete next char
`Ctrl-s`	– insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
`Ctrl-p`	– select previous history
`Ctrl-n`	– select next history
`Ctrl-r`	– insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
    <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                  <Home> – to first entry
                   <End> – to last entry
        Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
      Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
                 <enter> – open selected
            Alt-<enter> – open selected in the
                          background without
                          closing the picker
                 Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                 Ctrl-v – open vertically
                 Ctrl-t – toggle preview
            Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
    Ctrl-u – scroll up
    Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
      Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
         <enter> – close menu and accept completion
          Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
     Alt-p – previous signature
     Alt-n – next signature
```